

SPANISH POETRY BY HEART

The Words That Make You One of Them

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Border

Español

*¡Abenámar, Abenámar,
moro de la morería,
el día que tú naciste
grandes señales había!
Estaba la mar en calma,
la luna estaba crecida:
moro que en tal signo nace
no debe decir mentira.*

English

*Abenámar, Abenámar,
Moor of the Moorish lands,
on the day you were born
great omens filled the air!
The sea lay calm and still,
the moon was full and bright:
a Moor born under such a sign
must never speak a lie.*

Title: Romance de Abenámar (c 1431)

Author: Anónimo

The word *moro* appears in the first lines and might make us stumble before we start. Today it sounds like an insult, but in this poem it is not. To understand it, we need to take a small trip through time. In the Roman Empire, *maurus* was simply the name of the inhabitants of Mauretania, a strip of coast that today encompasses Morocco and part of Algeria. Nothing more than that. When the Muslim peoples crossed the strait in 711 and put an end to the Visigothic kingdom, those who watched them from the other side continued to use the same word to name them—not because of their faith, but because they came from those lands. Over time, *moro* came to simply mean Muslim, and much later, when coexistence turned into conflict, the word began to carry a derogatory connotation it didn't have before.

And it wasn't just in Spain: in 16th- and 17th-century Europe, Moor in English and *Maure* in French served exactly the same purpose. When Shakespeare writes The Tragedy of Othello, the Moore of Venice, he isn't using an exotic term but the common

Chapter 2

Castilla

Español

*Recuerde el alma dormida,
avive el seso y despierte
contemplando*

*cómo se pasa la vida,
cómo se viene la muerte
tan callando,*

*cuán presto se va el placer,
cómo, después de acordado,
da dolor;*

*cómo, a nuestro parecer,
cualquiera tiempo pasado
fue mejor. (...)*

*Nuestras vidas son los ríos
que van a dar en la mar,
que es el morir,*

*allí van los señorios
derechos a se acabar
y consumir;*

*allí los ríos caudales,
allí los otros medianos
y más chicos,*

*y llegados, son iguales
los que viven por sus manos
y los ricos. (...)*

English

*Let the sleeping soul remember,
let reason sharpen and awaken,
contemplating*

*how life passes us by,
how death arrives
so silently,*

*how swiftly pleasure fades,
how, once we call it to mind,
it turns to grief;*

*how, by our own reckoning,
any time now gone
seemed better. (...)*

*Our lives are the rivers
that flow into the sea,
which is dying;*

*there the great lordships go,
straight to their end
and dissolution;*

*there the mighty rivers,
there the middling ones
and the smaller,*

*and arriving, all are equal—
those who live by their hands
and the wealthy. (...)*

Title: Coplas por la muerte de su padre (1476)

Author: Jorge Manrique (c 1440 - 1479)

Manrique begins with three simple words: *recuerde, despierte, seso*. The last one may confuse today's reader. *Seso* is the capacity to think clearly, to see things as they are.

Italian Echoes

Español

*Si de mi baja lira
tanto pudiese el son que en un momento
apacase la ira
del animoso viento
y la furia del mar y el movimiento, (...)*

English

*If from my humble lyre
the sound could rise so high that in an
instant
it calmed the anger
of the restless wind
and the fury of the sea and its motion, (...)*

Title: A la flor de Gnido (1534)

Author: Garcilaso de la Vega (c 1500 - 1536)

The stanza opens with a condition left hanging: *Si de mi baja lira / tanto pudiese el son...* The adjective *baja* doesn't refer to the instrument's physical height or its size, but to its humble condition, its simplicity, something almost domestic—set against the forces mentioned next: the bold wind, the furious sea, the movement of the waters. The poet's lyre is small not in centimeters but in power, in reach, against the immensity of what it would like to subdue.

The *son* is the melody the lyre produces, the sound that comes from its strings. It's not the lyre itself that could calm the wind's rage, but that music capable—if the poet had the power of Orpheus—of soothing the most violent forces in the world. Orpheus is a mythological figure. He was a musician who could move any living being and even inanimate nature.

The almost mythical power the poet wishes for his lyre—able to calm the sea and bend the winds, like Orpheus—does not have as its ultimate purpose the domination of nature. It's an image that prepares the real aim: softening the beloved's heart of stone, that

Mysticism

Español

*Vivo sin vivir en mí,
y tan alta vida espero,
que muero porque no muero. (...)*

English

*I live without living in myself,
and I await such a high life,
that I die because I do not die. (...)*

Title: Glosa a lo divino (1571)

Author: Santa Teresa de Jesús (1515 - 1582)

The words are simple. Any child would understand them separately: to live, to die, to wait. But together they do something strange.

Teresa says she lives without living in herself. And that she dies because she doesn't die. Her life in this world is not the real life. The real life is somewhere else, higher up. So high, she says, that from here it can't be reached.

And while it can't be reached, each day that passes is a kind of small death. Not dying, for Teresa, is the problem. That's what hurts.

Three lines. Fifteen words. And yet everything is there.

Teresa says life three times and death twice. In such a small space, those two words collide, push against each other, contradict each other. To truly live you have to die. To reach the real life you have to die. To get to death you have to stay alive, which is another form of death when you're waiting.

A perfect paradox. The brevity is not an accident. It's the form.

University and Village

Español

*¡Qué descansada vida
la del que huye el mundanal rüido,
y sigue la escondida
senda, por donde han ido
los pocos sabios que en el mundo han sido!
(...)*

English

*How peaceful is the life
of one who flees the noise of the world,
and follows the hidden
path, where there have walked
the few wise men that the world has
known! (...)*

Title: Vida retirada (1572)

Author: Fray Luis de León (1527 - 1591)

Descansada means peaceful, balanced, free of conflict; *senda* is a narrow, little-traveled path; *sabio*, perhaps, the one who refuses to be ruled by his passions. The meaning of the stanza could be summed up like this: the few men who escape the world's clamor and do not surrender to their passions find a hidden path toward a quiet life.

Between the paraphrase and the poem, in any case, there is an abyss: that of culture and the passion for the beauty of language. Fray Luis was a professor.

The following stanzas develop that same idea: the rejection of fame, flattery, and the anguish of those who live dependent on the approval of others—and set against that, the image of the orchard planted by his own hands, the fountain, the air heavy with scent, the birds that wake without demanding anything. Nature is not scenery but chosen company.

The poem ends with an image of himself:

(...) A la sombra tendido,

Disdain

Español

*Ándeme yo caliente
y ríase la gente*

*Traten otros del gobierno
del mundo y sus monarquías,
mientras gobiernan mis días
mantequillas y pan tierno;
y las mañanas de invierno
naranjada y aguardiente,
y ríase la gente. (...)*

English

*Let me keep warm
and let the people laugh.*

*Let others deal with the governance
of the world and its monarchies,
while my days are ruled
by butter and soft bread;
and on winter mornings
by orange water and brandy,
and let the people laugh. (...)*

Title: *Ándeme yo caliente* (1581)

Author: Luis de Góngora (1561-1627)

Imagine a man walking in a ridiculous coat. It's too long, too flashy, perhaps with the wrong buttons. People laugh. He looks at them for a moment. Then he keeps walking.

He doesn't stop to explain himself. He doesn't change the coat. He doesn't frown. What matters to him is not being cold. The opinion of others is, in the end, other people's problem. And not just with the coat. Also with what he eats, what he drinks, how he spends winter mornings. With everything.

Góngora said it with more grace: *ándeme yo caliente, y ríase la gente* (let me keep warm and let the people laugh).

That butter and fresh bread should govern his days is not a figure of speech. It's a choice. And choices say more about a person than any speech.

Irony

Español

*Voto a Dios que me espanta esta grandeza
y que diera un doblón por describilla;
porque ¿a quién no sorprende y maravilla
esta máquina insigne, esta riqueza?*

*Por Jesucristo vivo, cada pieza
vale más de un millón, y que es mancilla
que esto no dure un siglo, ¡oh gran Sevilla!,
Roma triunfante en ánimo y nobleza.*

*Apostaré que el ánima del muerto
por gozar este sitio hoy ha dejado
la gloria donde vive eternamente.*

*Esto oyó un valentón, y dijo: "Es cierto
cuanto dice voacé, señor soldado.
Y el que dijere lo contrario, miente."*

*Y luego, incontinente,
caló el chapeo, requirió la espada,
miró al soslayo, fuese, y no hubo nada.*

English

*I swear to God this grandeur leaves me
stunned,
and I would give a doubloon to describe it;
for who is not surprised and filled with
wonder
at this magnificent machine, this wealth?*

*By the living Christ, each single piece
is worth more than a million, and it is a
shame
that this should last no century, O great
Seville!,
Rome triumphant in spirit and nobility.*

*I would wager that the soul of the dead
man
has left, to enjoy this place today,
the glory where it dwells for all eternity.*

*A swaggerer heard this, and said:
"Everything
your grace says is true, sir soldier.
And whoever says otherwise, lies."*

*And then, without delay,
he pulled his hat down, touched his sword,
glanced sideways, walked away, and that
was that.*

Title: Soneto al túmulo de Felipe II en Sevilla (1598)

Author: Miguel de Cervantes Saavedra (1547 - 1616)

When Philip II, the son of Emperor Charles V, whose domains spanned the globe, dies, a funeral monument is erected in Seville—a *túmulo*, meant to be dismantled after the funeral rites. Imagine a couple of soldiers contemplating it. That is exactly what the poem describes.

Satire

Español

*Érase un hombre a una nariz pegado,
érase una nariz superlativa,
érase una nariz sayón y escriba,
érase un peje espada muy barbado.*

*Érase un reloj de sol mal encarado,
érase una alquitara pensativa,
érase un elefante boca arriba,
era Ovidio Nasón más narizado.*

*Érase un espolón de una galera,
érase una pirámide de Egipto,
las doce Tribus de narices era.*

*Érase un naricísimo infinito,
muchísimo nariz, nariz tan fiera
que en la cara de Anás fuera delito.*

English

*There once was a man stuck to a nose,
there once was a superlative nose,
there once was a nose, hangman and
scribe,
there once was a heavily bearded
swordfish.*

*There once was a grim-faced sundial,
there once was a brooding alembic,
there once was an elephant lying on its
back,
it was Ovid Naso, but more nosed.*

*There once was the ram of a galley,
there once was a pyramid of Egypt,
it was the twelve Tribes of noses.*

*There once was an infinite nosiest of noses,
nose upon nose, a nose so fierce
that on the face of Annas it would be a
crime.*

Title: A un hombre de gran nariz (c 1603)

Author: Francisco de Quevedo y Villegas (1580 - 1645)

The vocabulary of the sonnet places the reader in Golden Age Spanish with a lexical density that mixes the learned, the technical, the biblical, and the classical. The *alquitara* is the distillation alembic, an apothecary's artifact whose elongated, curved shape was enough to evoke a disproportionate nose; the image is at once scientific and grotesque. *Peje espada* is the swordfish: the nose protrudes again as a sharp and outsized appendage. The *sayón* was the executioner or bailiff, a sinister figure recognizable on the street; pairing it with *escriba*, the man of letters, produces a nose that is at once threat and pedantry.

Sprezzatura

Español

*Un soneto me manda hacer Violante
y en mi vida me he visto en tal aprieto:
catorce versos dicen que es soneto:
burla burlando van los tres delante.*

*Yo pensé que no hallara consonante
y estoy a la mitad de otro cuarteto;
mas, si me veo en el primer terceto,
no hay cosa en los cuartetos que me
espante.*

*Por el primer terceto voy entrando
y aun presumo que entré con pie derecho,
pues fin con este verso le voy dando.*

*Ya estoy en el segundo, y aun sospecho
que estoy los trece versos acabando:
contad si son catorce, y está hecho.*

English

*Violante commands me to write a sonnet
and never have I found myself in such a fix:
fourteen lines, they say, is a sonnet —
and look, almost unwittingly, go the first
three.*

*I thought I would find no rhyme to carry
me
and already I am halfway through another
quatrain;
but if I make it to the first tercet,
nothing in the quatrains will frighten me
anymore.*

*Into the first tercet I now enter
and suspect I have come in on the right
foot,
for with this very line I am drawing it to a
close.*

*Now I am in the second, and I further
suspect
that I am finishing off line thirteen:
count them — if there are fourteen, it is
done.*

Title: El soneto de repente (La niña de plata) (c 1612)

Author: Félix Lope de Vega y Carpio (1562-1635).

There is an Italian word that the Spaniards of the sixteenth century borrowed with little attempt to hide it: *sprezzatura*.

Baldassare Castiglione invented it in 1528, in *The Book of the Courtier*, a treatise on how to behave at court. The idea is simple: true art consists in hiding art. The perfect courtier rides, dances, fights, and writes verse as if everything came to him without

Paradox

Español

*Cuentan de un sabio, que un día
tan pobre y mísero estaba,
que sólo se sustentaba
de unas yerbas que comía.
¿Habría otro -entre sí decía
más pobre y triste que yo?
Y cuando el rostro volvió
halló la respuesta, viendo
que iba otro sabio cogiendo
las hojas que él arrojó.*

English

*They tell of a wise man, who one day
was so poor and wretched
that he sustained himself only
on some herbs he ate.
"Could there be another," he said to
himself,
"poorer and sadder than I?"
And when he turned his face
he found the answer, seeing
that another wise man was gathering
the leaves he had thrown away.*

Title: La vida es sueño (1635)

Author: Pedro Calderón de la Barca (1600 - 1681)

The vocabulary here is transparent, aside from a few turns of phrase now fallen out of use. *Mísero* is not a mere redundancy of *pobre*: it adds a shade of indignity or pity, closer to wretched than to a simple synonym. *Entre sí decía* amounts to *pensaba*, to saying something to oneself without speaking it aloud. And *el rostro volvió*, with the inverted word order typical of classical verse, is nothing more than *volvió el rostro* (he turned his face) or *volvió la cabeza* (he turned his head).

This small poem belongs to *La vida es sueño*, Calderón's masterwork. The sage believes he has hit bottom—eating grass is the last rung of poverty—until he discovers someone else gathering precisely what he throws away: what for one man is nothing at all, for another is sustenance. Misfortune suddenly ceases to be a fixed fact and reveals itself as a relative position, always reversible from another angle.

Moral

Español

*Llevaba en la cabeza
una lechera el cántaro al mercado
con aquella presteza,
aquel aire sencillo, aquel agrado,
que va diciendo a todo el que lo advierte,
¡yo sí que estoy contenta con mi suerte! (...)*

English

*A milkmaid carried on her head
the jug to market,
with such quickness,
such a simple air, such pleasantness,
that it seems to tell everyone who notices
her,
how happy I am with my lot in life! (...)*

Title: La lechera (1781)

Author: Félix María de Samaniego (1745 - 1801)

The *cántaro* is a clay pitcher you can carry on your head. *Presteza* is swiftness, quickness of movement—the milkmaid walks with a light and decided step. The *aire* is not the air you breathe, but bearing, the way you move and present yourself. And *advierte* doesn't mean warning of danger here: it simply means noticing, perceiving—anyone who sees her pass.

In 1700 Spain changed dynasties. Charles II, the last of the Habsburgs, died without children, and a month before his death he signed in his will the sentence establishing who would inherit the throne: Philip of Bourbon, Duke of Anjou, grandson of the French king Louis XIV. The decision pleased almost no one in Europe, and the entire continent went to war to undo it: the War of the Spanish Succession became, within Spain, a civil war.

The Bourbons won, and with the victory came a different country: more centralized, more French, less made up of scattered kingdoms. That same dynasty, through abdications, exiles, a dictatorship, and two republics in between, still occupies

Fantasy

Español

*Con diez cañones por banda,
Viento en popa, a toda vela,
No corta el mar, sino vuela
Un velero bergantín:*

*Bajel pirata que llaman
Por su bravura el Temido,
En todo el mar conocido
Del uno al otro confín. (...)*

*Y ve el capitán pirata,
Cantando alegre en la popa,
Asia a un lado, a otro Europa,
Y allá a su frente Estambul.*

*Navega, velero mío,
Sin temor,
Que ni enemigo navío,
Ni tormenta, ni bonanza
Tu rumbo a torcer alcanza,
Ni a sujetar tu valor. (...)*

*Que es mi barco mi tesoro,
Que es mi Dios la libertad,
Mi ley, la fuerza y el viento,
Mi única patria la mar.*

English

*With ten cannons to a side,
Wind behind, full sail,
It doesn't cut the sea, it flies,
A swift brigantine:*

*A pirate ship they call,
For its daring, the Feared One,
Known on every sea
From one end to the other. (...)*

*And the pirate captain watches,
Singing gladly at the stern,
Asia on one side, Europe on the other,
And there ahead, Istanbul.*

*Sail on, my ship,
Without fear,
For no enemy vessel,
Nor storm, nor calm
Can bend your course,
Nor curb your courage. (...)*

*For my ship is my treasure,
For my God is freedom,
My law, force and the wind,
My only homeland the sea.*

Title: Canción del pirata (1835)

Author: José de Espronceda (1808 - 1842)

The *bajel* is simply a ship or vessel, but it's an archaic word even in Spanish—Espronceda uses it for its solemn, nautical sonority, not because it was in common usage in 1835. The *banda* in *diez cañones por banda* has nothing to do with band in English: it's the side of the ship, so the vessel carries ten cannons on each side. The *popa* is the stern (the opposite of the *proa*), and that's where the captain sings. The *bonanza* simply means calm seas,

Redemption

Español

*¿No es cierto, ángel de amor,
que en esta apartada orilla
más pura la luna brilla
y se respira mejor?*

English

*Isn't it true, angel of love,
that on this secluded shore
the moon shines purer
and the air is easier to breathe?*

Title: Don Juan Tenorio (1844)

Author: José Zorrilla (1817 - 1893)

These verses belong to *Don Juan Tenorio* (1844), the Romantic drama by José Zorrilla. Spain, a country not prone to exporting heroes without cracks, has given the literary world a series of figures that are precisely that—cracks turned into archetypes. There's the idealist who mistakes windmills for giants and ends up leaving the reader wondering who is truly mad; there's his squire, who stands for the common sense that never wins but never quite loses either; there's the pícaro, who survives on hunger and wit; and there's Segismundo, asking himself whether life itself might not be a dream inside another dream.

Don Juan joins that family. Zorrilla didn't invent the character—he already appeared in Tirso de Molina and Molière—but he gave him a Romantic reading.

That abduction of a convent novice—Doña Inés steps out of her enclosure not quite sure whether she's dreaming or living the most dangerous dream of her life—ends at the estate Don Juan owns on the banks of the Guadalquivir, already outside Seville but with the city silhouetted in the background, its towers and lights as a backdrop for that night.

Beauty

Español

*Del salón en el ángulo oscuro,
de su dueño tal vez olvidada,
silenciosa y cubierta de polvo
veíase el arpa.*

*¡Cuánta nota dormía en sus cuerdas,
como el pájaro duerme en las ramas,
esperando la mano de nieve
que sabe arrancarla!*

*¡Ay! -pensé-. ¡Cuántas veces el genio
así duerme en el fondo del alma,
y una voz, como Lázaro, espera
que le diga: «Levántate y anda!»*

English

*In the dark corner of the parlor,
perhaps forgotten by its owner,
silent and covered in dust,
the harp could be seen.*

*How many notes slept in its strings,
as the bird sleeps in the branches,
waiting for the hand of snow
that knows how to draw them out!*

*Ah! —I thought—. How many times genius
sleeps like this in the depths of the soul,
and a voice, like Lazarus, waits
for someone to say to it: "Rise and walk!"*

Title: Rima VII (Del salón en el ángulo oscuro) (c 1860)

Author: Gustavo Adolfo Bécquer (1836 - 1870)

Mano de nieve is not a cold hand: it's a white hand, delicate, almost immaterial—the hand of a woman in the Romantic imagination, one that touches without effort and for that very reason seems to have an almost supernatural power. *Arrancarla*s, applied to the notes, carries a hint of violence that everyday Spanish no longer notices: it's not *tocar* the harp, it's tearing something out of it that was inside, like wrenching an answer from someone who resists. And the allusion to Lazarus takes for granted that the reader knows the whole miracle—Christ facing the tomb, four days dead, the dry command: "Rise and walk." Without that background, the last line is just a pretty phrase; with it, it's a promise of resurrection.

Sensitivity

Español

*Yo voy soñando caminos
de la tarde. ¡Las colinas
doradas, los verdes pinos,
las polvorientas encinas!...
¿Adónde el camino irá?
Yo voy cantando, viajero
a lo largo del sendero...
—La tarde cayendo está—.*

*«En el corazón tenía
la espina de una pasión;
logré arrancármela un día:
ya no siento el corazón».*

*Y todo el campo un momento
se queda, mudo y sombrío,
meditando. Suena el viento
en los álamos del río.*

*La tarde más se oscurece;
y el camino que serpea
y débilmente blanquea,
se enturbia y desaparece.*

*Mi cantar vuelve a plañir:
«Aguda espina dorada,
quién te pudiera sentir
en el corazón clavada».*

English

*I go dreaming along the paths
of the afternoon. The golden
hills, the green pine trees,
the dusty holm oaks!...
Where will the path lead?
I go singing, a traveler
along the trail...
— The afternoon is falling. —*

*"In my heart I carried
the thorn of a passion;
one day I managed to pull it out,
I no longer feel my heart."*

*And all the countryside for a moment
falls silent and somber,
in meditation. The wind sounds
through the poplars by the river.*

*The afternoon grows darker still,
and the path that winds
and faintly gleams white
grows dim and disappears.*

*My song returns to lament:
"Sharp golden thorn,
if only I could feel you
driven into my heart."*

Title: Soledades. Poema XI (1903)

Author: Antonio Machado (1875 - 1939)

Four words anchor the poem in a very specific landscape. The *encina* is an evergreen tree of the Castilian plateau, smaller and darker than the English oak. Machado calls these trees *polvorientas*, and it's not that they have more dust than the other trees along the road: it's that their green is muted, almost grayish, as if faded, completely different from the vivid, bright

Esperpento

Español

(...) Como un asesino
Grazna el bombardino
Sacando la nuez,
Y el clarín se irrita,
Y se despepita
Su lengua soez.
El señor Serapio
Reparte el morapio
Con esplendidez. (...)

English

(...) Like a murderer
the bombardino caws,
straining its throat,
and the bugle grows irritated,
and shrieks itself raw,
its vulgar tongue.
Mister Serapio
hands out the cheap wine
with lavish generosity. (...)

Title: Vista madrileña (La pipa de Kif) (1919)

Author: Ramón María de Valle-Inclán (1866 - 1936)

This passage from Valle-Inclán is full of words almost nobody uses anymore, and that's exactly its charm.

The *bombardino* is a brass instrument, a big cousin of the flugelhorn, with a deep and somewhat ridiculous sound. When the poem says it *grazna*, it's comparing it to a crow's caw—an ugly sound, not a musical one. Right from the first line, the instrument stops being an instrument and becomes a bird of ill omen.

Then the clarion, offended by the competition, *despepita*. This verb comes from fruit seeds—imagine a pomegranate bursting open all at once, scattering its seeds in every direction. In colloquial language it means to act in an exuberant way, and, applied to an instrument, it means it sounds uncontrolled, almost hysterical. Its sound is a *lengua soez*, that is, a coarse, foul-mouthed voice. The clarion doesn't just sound bad: it sounds like someone swearing.

Spirituality

Español

*Río Duero, río Duero,
nadie a acompañarte baja;
nadie se detiene a oír
tu eterna estrofa de agua. (...)*

*Quién pudiera como tú,
a la vez quieto y en marcha,
cantar siempre el mismo verso
pero con distinta agua. (...)*

English

*Duero river, Duero river,
no one comes down to join you;
no one stops to listen
to your eternal stanza of water. (...)*

*Who could be like you,
at once still and in motion,
always singing the same verse
but with different water. (...)*

Title: Romance del Duero (1923)

Author: Gerardo Diego (1896 - 1987)

It was in Soria, the same city where Machado had lived and taught years before, and where he also held a high school teaching position, that Gerardo Diego wrote these lines to the Duero.

Between the two stanzas, the situation barely changes: no one goes down to keep the River Duero company. The city turns its back on it because it doesn't want to recognize itself in its aged reflection. But the river continues on its course, carrying in its waters the words of lovers. Those words don't wear out or repeat, because each time a different water carries them. What is abandonment for the city is continuity for the lovers: the river as permanent witness to the same human gesture that never ages, even though different people always play the part.

Gerardo Diego Cendoya was born in Santander on October 3, 1896, the seventh child of a textile merchant family, pious to the point of giving two Jesuit brothers to the Church. His childhood

Duende

Español

*Verde que te quiero verde.
Verde viento. Verdes ramas.
El barco sobre la mar
y el caballo en la montaña.
Con la sombra en la cintura
ella sueña en su baranda,
verde carne, pelo verde,
con ojos de fría plata.
Verde que te quiero verde.
Bajo la luna gitana,
las cosas la están mirando
y ella no puede mirarlas. (...)*

English

*Green, how I want you green.
Green wind. Green branches.
The ship out on the sea
and the horse on the mountain.
With the shadow at her waist
she dreams on her balcony,
green flesh, green hair,
with eyes of cold silver.
Green, how I want you green.
Under the gypsy moon,
things are looking at her
and she cannot look at them. (...)*

Title: Romance Sonámbulo (1928)

Author: Federico García Lorca (1898 - 1936)

The fragment belongs to the *Romance Sonámbulo* (Sleepwalking Ballad) included in the *Romancero gitano* (Gypsy Ballads). In a lecture-recital, Lorca had this to say about the poem: *uno de los más misteriosos del libro ... Es un hecho poético puro del fondo andaluz, y siempre tendrá luces cambiantes, aun para el hombre que lo ha comunicado, que soy yo.* (one of the most mysterious poems in the book ... It is a pure poetic fact from the depths of Andalusia, and it will always have shifting lights, even for the man who has communicated it—myself).

It's no surprise it has been interpreted in very different ways. This is a simple and nearly literal reading.

It's a story told by a narrator, in which dialogues appear between the various characters. It's sleepwalking because it stages an action inside a dream. The action takes place in two time frames.

Elegy

Español

*Yo quiero ser llorando el hortelano
de la tierra que ocupas y estercolas,
compañero del alma, tan temprano.*

*Alimentando lluvias, caracolas
y órganos mi dolor sin instrumento,
a las desalentadas amapolas*

*daré tu corazón por alimento.
tanto dolor se agrupa en mi costado,
que por doler me duele hasta el aliento. (...) that from hurting, it even hurts to breathe.
(...)*

English

*Weeping, I want to be the gardener
of the earth you occupy and fertilize,
companion of my soul, so early.*

*Feeding rains, snail shells
and organs, my grief without an
instrument,
to the disheartened poppies*

*I will give your heart as food.
so much pain gathers in my side,
that from hurting, it even hurts to breathe.
(...)*

Title: Elegía (A Ramón Sijé) (1935)

Author: Miguel Hernández (1910 - 1942)

Hernández chooses *hortelano* over *jardinero* because a hortelano doesn't grow flowers, he grows food: he digs, manures, harvests with his hands in the earth. It's a trade of subsistence, not ornament, and it fits the poet's own biography—son of a goatherd, a shepherd himself before he was a poet. When he offers himself as hortelano of the earth that covers his dead friend, he doesn't promise flowers on the grave: he promises physical labor, sweat, the same kind of manual effort with which Hernández knew the world before he knew books. *Estercolas* completes that agricultural image without euphemism—he doesn't say the earth nourishes the body, he says it does so with manure, with the crudest, least poetic word available in Spanish for that process. And *órganos* is not a musical instrument but the speaker's own viscera: pain finds no outlet outside the body and ends up feeding on itself, from within, with the same logic of raw

Exile

Español

*Se equivocó la paloma
se equivocaba.
Por ir al norte, fue al sur
creyó que el trigo era agua,
se equivocaba. (...)*

English

*The dove was wrong,
she was mistaken.
Going north, she went south,
she thought the wheat was water,
she was mistaken. (...)*

Title: Se equivocó la paloma (1941)

Author: Rafael Alberti (1902 - 1999)

What strikes you is how bare the vocabulary is. No learned words, not a single word a child wouldn't know. The refrain *se equivocaba* works almost like a heartbeat, and the play of opposites builds meaning by accumulation, not by explanation.

The poem never explains what kind of mistake the dove makes, and that ambiguity is deliberate. Each stanza proposes a different scenario, and the reader can settle on any one of them, or all of them at once.

Throughout the entire poem, that uncertainty persists, deliberately never resolved. It takes the form of a song as a result—that kind of beauty that holds itself up without needing explanation.

Rafael Alberti was born in El Puerto de Santa María, on the bay of Cádiz, on December 16, 1902. Before he was a poet, he wanted to be a painter, and for years he was one in earnest: he painted the ships and ocean liners that entered his home port, that seafaring Andalusia that would never stop showing up in his verses even after he'd been living far from it for decades.